

Skills Summary

Comparing Numerals 1 to 10

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Comparing two numbers

Rule: $<$ is *less than*, $>$ is *greater than*, $=$ is *equal to*.

The wide open end of the symbol always faces the *bigger* number; the point faces the smaller one.

Counting order: the later a number is said when you count up, the bigger it is.

Example: Write $<$, $>$, or $=$ between 4 and 7.

Step 1. I need to know which numeral stands for more, and counting order tells me that, so I count up and listen for which one I say later.

Step 2. Counting up I say 4 first and 7 later, so 7 is the bigger number. The wide end faces 7, which is on the right.

$$4 < 7$$

Try it: Write $<$, $>$, or $=$ between 9 and 6.

$$9 < 6$$
 check

(!) Watch out: The symbol does not always point the same way. Look at the numbers first, then turn the wide end toward the bigger one.

Skill 2 — One more and one less

Rule: One more is the next number you say counting up; one less is the number you say just before.

A number is always *greater than* the number one less than it, and *less than* the number one more than it.

Example: From 6: what is one more, and what is one less? Then compare.

Step 1. One more and one less are neighbours in the counting order, so I count on once and count back once from the same number.

Step 2. Counting on from 6 gives 7; counting back from 6 gives 5. The neighbour ahead is bigger and the neighbour behind is smaller.

one more: 7 one less: 5

Try it: From 3: write one more, then one less.

check: one more 4, one less 2

Skill 3 — Putting three numbers in order

Rule: Least to greatest means smallest first. Say the counting numbers and write each of your three numerals down as you reach it.

Example: Put 8, 3, 5 in order from least to greatest.

Step 1. Ordering three numbers is just comparing, done twice, so I walk through the counting order once and take each numeral as it comes up.

Step 2. Counting up I reach 3 first, then 5, then 8. That is the order from least to greatest.
3, 5, 8

Try it: Put 6, 10, 2 in order from least to greatest.

check: 2, 6, 10

Skill 4 — Checking a comparison

Rule: To check a comparison someone else wrote, cover the symbol, decide for yourself which number is bigger, then look: does the wide end face that number?

Example: Is $9 < 2$ right? If not, write the correct symbol.

Step 1. The claim is that 9 is smaller, so I test it by counting instead of by looking at the symbol.

Step 2. Counting up I say 2 first and 9 later, so 9 is the bigger number. The wide end must face 9, not 2.

$9 > 2$

Try it: Is $3 > 8$ right? If not, write the correct symbol.

check: $8 > 3$